Grammar reference

EnglishCamp | Eleven practical reference sections

Rules, sentence forms and contextual examples. This English-language print edition uses the same reference data as the website. Arabic support remains available in the online examples.

Topics: Sentence structure | Tense and aspect | Articles and countability | Prepositions | Linking words | Passive voice | Conditionals | Relative clauses | Agreement and pronouns | Questions and negatives | Modals and verb patterns

Sentence structure

Basic Word Order: SVO (Subject-Verb-Object)

The usual order in a neutral English statement is subject + verb + object when the verb takes an object. Questions, imperatives and some emphatic constructions follow other patterns. Arabic also permits different orders, so compare complete sentence structures rather than translating word by word.

I eat an apple.

She reads a book.

SVO Rule: Neutral transitive statement: subject -> verb -> object; Questions and special constructions may use inversion; imperatives often begin with a verb.; Adjectives come BEFORE nouns: a red car (not: a car red)

Adding place, time and adverbs

When you have multiple elements in a sentence, English follows this order: Subject + Verb + Object + Place + Time. Time can also go at the START of the sentence for emphasis. Adverbs of frequency (always, never, often) go BEFORE the main verb.

I met my friend at the café yesterday.

Yesterday I met my friend at the café.

SPOT rule: S = Subject: I, You, He, She, etc.; V = Verb: the action word; O = Object: who/what receives the action; P = Place: where? (at home, in the park, in Cairo); T = Time: when? (yesterday, at 5 PM, last week)

Adverb placement: Adverbs of frequency (always, usually, often, sometimes, never) -> BEFORE main verb: She always arrives on time.; BUT after 'be' verb: He is always late.; Adverbs of manner (quickly, carefully) -> AFTER verb: He drove carefully.; Place before time: I saw him at the park yesterday.

Question Formation (Yes/No & WH)

Yes/No questions are formed by inverting the subject and the auxiliary verb (do/does/did, be, have, modals). WH-questions add the question word at the beginning. Subject questions such as Who called? normally keep subject-verb order without adding do. Embedded questions also use statement order.

Do you like coffee?

Where do you live?

Yes/No question formation: With 'be': invert subject and be-verb - Are you ready? / Is he here?; With main-verb have: Do you have a car? is widely used. Have you got a car? is common in British English; Have you a car? also occurs in some varieties.; With other verbs: Do/Does/Did + subject + base verb - Does she work here? / Did you see him?; With modals: Modal + subject + base verb - Can you swim? / Should I go?

WH question formation: WH-word (what/where/when/why/who/how) + auxiliary + subject + verb?; Who/What + verb (when subject) - Who called you? / What happened?; Prepositions at the end (informal) - Who are you talking TO? / Where do you come FROM?

Negatives (not, never, no)

To make a sentence negative in English, add 'not' after the auxiliary verb (be, do, have, modals). For simple present/past without an auxiliary, use 'do not / does not / did not' + base verb. 'Never' replaces 'not' and is used before the main verb.

I am not tired.

She does not (doesn't) like spicy food.

Negation rules: With 'be': subject + be + not: I am not, he is not, they are not; With modals: subject + modal + not: I cannot, you must not, she will not (won't); With other verbs: do/does/did + not + base verb: I don't know, she doesn't work, they didn't come; No vs. Not: 'no' goes before nouns (no money, no time), 'not' negates verbs (not happy, not going)

Tense and aspect

Present simple / continuous

Use the simple form for routines and general states; use am/is/are + -ing for activity in progress or a temporary situation. Many state verbs normally use the simple form.

I work in a library. I am working from home this week.

Past simple / continuous

Past simple locates a completed past event; was/were + -ing presents activity in progress at a past point.

I was cooking when the phone rang.

Present perfect / past simple

Have/has + past participle connects earlier time with now. Use past simple for an event at a finished past time such as yesterday.

I have lost my keys: I cannot get in. I lost them yesterday.

Past perfect

Had + past participle presents an event as earlier than another past reference point.

The train had left before we reached the station.

Future choices

Will can express a promise or immediate decision. Be going to can express an intention or a prediction based on present evidence. Present continuous can describe an arrangement.

I'll help you. Look at those clouds: it's going to rain. I'm meeting Salma at six.

Articles and countability

A / an

Use a/an with a singular countable noun when introducing one unspecified instance. Choose by the following sound, not its written letter.

a university; an hour; an interesting book

The / no article

The often identifies something already known or specified. General plural and uncountable nouns often have no article.

The book on the desk is mine. Books can be expensive. Water is essential.

Countable / uncountable

Use many/fewer with plural countable nouns and much/less with uncountable nouns. Advice and information are normally uncountable in these uses.

two pieces of advice; some information; fewer mistakes; less noise

Prepositions

Time

Use at for clock times, on for days/dates and in for months/years. Fixed phrases include at night. For names a duration; since names its starting point.

at - Specific time: The meeting starts at 3 PM.

in - Months, years, seasons, parts of day: I was born in July.

on - Days and dates: See you on Monday.

during - Throughout a period: He slept during the movie.

since - From a starting point until now: I have studied English since 2020.

until - Up to a point: The store is open until 9 PM.

for two hours; since Monday; during the lesson; by Friday (deadline); until Friday (continuing up to then).

Location

A preposition describes a relationship: at a point, on a surface, in an area or container. The intended meaning determines the choice.

at - Specific point or place: She is at the bus stop.

in - Inside an area or container: The book is in my bag.

on - Surface: The cat is on the roof.

between - In the middle of two things: The bank is between the café and the library.

under - Below or beneath: The cat is under the table.

over - Above, covering: A plane flew over the city.

near - Close to: I live near the station.

beside - Next to: She sat beside me.

Direction

Distinguish location from movement: in/into, on/onto. To identifies a destination; from identifies an origin.

to - Movement toward a destination: I am going to school.

from - Origin or starting point: I am from Egypt.

into - Entering a space: He walked into the room.

out of - Leaving a space: She came out of the building.

across - From one side to the other: He swam across the river.

through - From inside to the other side: We walked through the tunnel.

Other relationships

Prepositions express relationships and occur in established combinations. Object pronouns follow prepositions: for me, with her, between us.

to - Recipient (indirect object): Give the book to me.

for - Purpose, duration, benefit: This gift is for you.

with - Accompaniment, instrument: I went with my friends.

by - Agent, method, transport: She goes to work by bus.

about - Topic or subject: We talked about the project.

of - Belonging, origin, contents: The cover of the book is red.

Linking words

Causal

Reason / cause (because, since, therefore)

I learn English because I want to work abroad.

Since it is raining, we are staying at home.

As I was tired, I went to bed early.

Concessive

Despite / although (although, however, despite)

Although it rained, we went for a walk.

Even though it was difficult, we succeeded.

He was tired, though he continued working.

Conditional

If / unless (if, unless, otherwise)

If I have time, I will come by.

Unless it rains, the event will be outdoors.

Hurry up; otherwise, we will miss the bus.

Temporal

Time (when, while, after, before, until)

When I was young, I traveled a lot.

While I cook, I listen to music.

Before we eat, we wash our hands.

Modal

Manner / method (by, as if, without)

You save time by shopping online.

He acts as if he knew nothing.

He left without saying goodbye.

Final

Purpose (so that, in order to)

I explain it to you so that you understand.

She saves money in order to buy a car.

I went to the store to buy milk.

Consecutive

Result (so...that, consequently, as a result)

It was so cold that we shivered.

It was such a good movie that we watched it twice.

He did not study; consequently, he failed.

Adversative

Contrast (but, however, whereas, on the other hand)

I wanted to come, but I had no time.

The hotel was cheap, however not very clean.

She works quickly, whereas he is very slow.

Enumerating

Ordering (first, then, finally, firstly)

First, we wash the vegetables; then we cut them.

First I shower; then I have breakfast.

Next, we add the sugar and stir.

Restrictive

Limitation (admittedly, however, even though)

Admittedly the weather was bad, but the vacation was still nice.

The apartment is nice, however very small.

To some extent, the result depends on the weather.

Addition

Adding info (also, furthermore, moreover, and)

I buy bread and milk.

I like pizza, and I also like pasta.

The restaurant is cheap. In addition, it is centrally located.

Passive voice

Present Simple Passive

The passive voice shifts focus from who does the action to the action itself or who receives it. Formed with 'am/is/are' + past participle. Use 'by' to mention the agent.

The letter is written by Sarah.

English is spoken here.

Past Simple Passive

The past simple passive describes a completed action in the past where the focus is on the action or recipient, not the doer. Formed with 'was/were' + past participle.

The letter was written yesterday.

The windows were cleaned last week.

Passive in All Tenses

Many transitive verb constructions have passive forms using be + past participle; the auxiliary carries tense and aspect. Some extended forms are rare and are usually reworded. Intransitive verbs such as arrive do not normally form a passive. A by-phrase may identify the agent when relevant.

The report is being written now.

The report was being written when I arrived.

Passive with Modal Verbs

Modal verbs (can, must, should, might, etc.) combine with the passive to express obligation, possibility, permission, or advice about an action without focusing on who does it.

The homework must be done by Friday.

This door can be opened easily.

Conditionals

Zero Conditional - General Truths

The zero conditional expresses general truths, scientific facts, and habits - things that are always true when the condition is met. Both clauses use the present simple tense. The 'if' can be replaced with 'when' with no change in meaning.

If you heat ice, it melts.

If it rains, the ground gets wet.

First Conditional - Real Future Possibilities

The first conditional expresses a real possibility in the future. The 'if' clause uses present simple, and the main clause uses 'will' + base verb. The condition is likely or possible to happen. This is the most common conditional for talking about future plans.

If it rains tomorrow, I will stay at home.

If you study hard, you will pass the exam.

Second Conditional - Unreal Present/Future

The second conditional expresses unreal or unlikely situations in the present or future. The 'if' clause uses past simple, and the main clause uses 'would' + base verb. 'Were' is used instead of 'was' for all subjects in formal English (If I were...).

If I had a million dollars, I would travel the world.

If I were you, I would accept the job offer.

Third Conditional - Unreal Past

The third conditional expresses regret or hypothetical situations in the past - things that did NOT happen but could have. The 'if' clause uses past perfect (had + past participle), and the main clause uses 'would have' + past participle.

If I had studied harder, I would have passed the exam.

If you had called me, I would have come.

Relative clauses

Relative Pronouns Basics

A relative clause gives more information about a noun in the main clause. The relative pronoun introduces the relative clause and refers back to the noun (the antecedent). Choose the pronoun based on whether the antecedent is a person, thing, place, time, or reason.

The woman who called you is my sister. (who = person, subject)

The book which I borrowed is excellent. (which = thing, object)

Defining vs Non-Defining Relative Clauses

A DEFINING relative clause identifies which person or thing we are talking about. It is essential to the meaning - without it, the sentence is unclear. A NON-DEFINING relative clause adds extra information and is enclosed in commas. It can be removed without changing the core meaning.

DEFINING: The students who study hard will pass. (only those who study hard)

NON-DEFINING: The students, who study hard, will pass. (all students, and they all study hard)

Who vs Whom (and When to Use Each)

'Who' is used as the subject of the relative clause (the doer of the action). 'Whom' is used as the object (the receiver of the action). In informal modern English, 'who' is often used for both, while 'whom' is reserved for formal writing. 'That' can replace 'who' in defining clauses.

The teacher who taught me is retiring. (who = subject of 'taught')

The teacher whom I admired is retiring. (whom = object of 'admired')

Which vs That (Defining vs Non-Defining for Things)

Use 'that' ONLY in DEFINING relative clauses (no commas). Use 'which' in NON-DEFINING clauses (with commas). In defining clauses about things, both which and that are possible. Some American editorial styles prefer that for defining clauses; British English commonly permits either. Non-defining clauses about things use which, not that.

DEFINING: The laptop that I bought is broken. (identifies which laptop)

NON-DEFINING: My laptop, which I bought last year, is broken. (extra info)

Agreement and pronouns

Find the subject head

The head of the subject normally determines subject-verb agreement. A nearby noun inside a modifier does not replace it.

The list of activities is on the desk. The activities are interesting.

Subject / object / possessive

Use I/he/she/we/they as subjects; me/him/her/us/them as objects, including after prepositions. A possessive determiner comes before its noun.

She helped me. This is for her. Their car is outside; that one is theirs.

Questions and negatives

Questions with auxiliaries

Put the auxiliary before the subject. With ordinary present/past simple verbs, use do/does/did + subject + base verb.

Are you ready? Where does she work? Why did they leave?

Indirect questions

After an opener such as Could you tell me, use statement order inside the embedded question.

Where is the station? Could you tell me where the station is?

Negation

Add not after an auxiliary; otherwise use do/does/did not + base verb. Standard English normally avoids a second negative for the same meaning.

She does not drive. They have not arrived. I did not see anyone.

Modals and verb patterns

Modal + base verb

Can, must, may, might and should take the base form without to. Have to and ought to follow different patterns.

She can swim. You should rest. We have to leave.

Modal perfect

Modal + have + past participle refers to an earlier situation. The modal expresses possibility, deduction or evaluation.

He might have missed the bus. You should have checked the time.

Infinitive / -ing

The first verb or expression helps determine the next form. Some verbs permit both with a change of meaning.

I enjoy reading. I hope to travel. I stopped smoking. I stopped to buy a ticket.

Study reference. Examples are learning material, not examination-board questions.